

Given and New Information

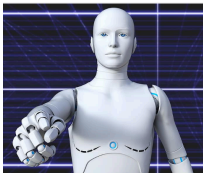


In this module, you will learning how to write cohesive and coherent texts. To do this well, you need a better understanding of the structure of sentences and clauses as well as of the concepts of Given and New. Please complete the following:

1. Read the text, which explains the structure of a sentence in terms of Given and New information.
2. Check your understanding of Given and New information by doing the activity.



Readings



Essential: Given and New information

Main point

Always start a sentence with information that the reader already knows or has seen before in the writing.

Never start a sentence with information that the reader has not seen before in the writing.

The structure of a sentence

To improve your writing skills, it is important to understand the "texture" of a sentence.

Before reading, think about what you already know about how to write a sentence.

Sentences

1. *Sentences begin with a capital letter.*
- 2.
- 3.
- 4.

Beginnings and endings of sentences

Read the following text and answer the question:

What is New information?

Sentences

Understanding Clause and Sentence Structure

A sentence can have **one or more clauses**.

A **clause** usually contains a **verb group**.

- **One clause:** *After class, I **study** with my friends.*
 - **Two clauses:** *After I **finish** class, I **study** with my friends.*
 - **Three clauses:** *After I **finish** class, I **go** home and I **study** with my friends.*
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Clause Structure: Beginning and Ending

Clauses usually have a **beginning** and an **ending**.

- The **beginning** is usually the **person or thing** being talked about.

Example: *The good student* studies with her friends.

In writing, we call this beginning the **Given**.

It is information the reader already knows or has seen before in the text.

In most written sentences, the **Given** is the **Subject**.

- The **ending** gives **new information** about the person or thing in the Given.
We call this the **New**.
It is information the reader does **not yet know**.

Example: The good student studies with her friends.

Given New information flow table activity

Beginning	Ending
Given/Subject	New
This paper	explores the impact of social media use on productivity.
Technology	has had a significant impact on communication.
The table	shows the results of the survey.

The reader must have seen the Subject before in the text or knows what the Subject refers to. If the reader cannot link the Subject back to a previous mention of the Subject, there is a lack of cohesion and coherence.



Further exploration into Given & New



Expanding the Given

Other types of words can come before the Subject. These words before the Subject are also considered part of the Given.

1. Transition Signals

Some transition signals must come **before the Subject** in the second part of a sentence:

- “**but**”, “**so**”, “**and**”

Other signals can come **before or after the Subject**:

- “**however**”, “**consequently**”, “**in addition**”

Examples:

- *The student studies every night, **but he** plays badminton on the weekends.*
 - *The student studies every night; **however, he** plays badminton on the weekends.*
 - *The student studies every night; **he** plays badminton on the weekends, however.*
-

2. Opinions or Judgements

(Not always suitable for academic writing)

Examples:

- ***Unfortunately, the student** didn't pass.*
 - ***Importantly, students** should attend every class.*
 - ***I think this method** is useful.*
 - ***In my opinion, this method** is useful.*
-

3. Circumstances (Time, Place, Source)

These are **prepositional phrases** that show **when**, **where**, or **who** the information comes from.

Examples:

- ***In 2012, the student** didn't study enough.*
 - ***According to Collins (2009), students** need more support.*
 - ***In this essay, I** will discuss academic integrity.*
 - ***In the next part of the presentation, we** will look at examples.*
-

Summary

In a sentence, the **Subject** is part of the **Given**.

You can place a **transition signal**, an **opinion**, or a **prepositional phrase** before the Subject.

You can use **all three**, or just the Subject alone.

If there is only one element in the Given, it must be the **Subject**.

Example:

Sentence:

The scientist was mixing chemicals, but unfortunately, in the middle of the night, the mixture exploded.

Given:

The scientist

New:

was mixing chemicals

Given:

but unfortunately, in the middle of the night, the mixture

New:

exploded.

Check your understanding

To check your understanding of Given & New, state whether the sentences are True or False.

The Subject should be put in the Given.

☐ True

☐ False

✓ Check



↻ Reuse

I am confused 🚩



Check your understanding

Given and New information

Writing clear sentences helps your reader follow your thoughts; in turn, it makes your writing more compelling and influential. Therefore, it is important that you understand the concepts Given and New.

Do the activity below to check your understanding.

Drag the words into the correct boxes.

A sentence has two parts: a beginning and an ending. The beginning can be called Given while the ending can be called New. The term Given means that the information is already known to the reader. The reader may have seen the information before in the text. New information, on the other hand, is information that the reader has not seen before. To help your reader understand your text, and to make your text coherent, you should never put new information at the beginning of a sentence. The subject of a sentence or clause is in the subject position. This means that the Subject - what you are talking about, is always known to the reader.

Subject

known

New

cohesive

Given

ending

known

New

not

text

✓ Submit

🔄 Reuse

I am confused 🚩



Questions & Answers

Given and New information

If you have any questions, or would like to discuss answers, please post in the

Textual Module: Q&A Discussion Forum

(https://canvas.utscollege.edu.au/courses/7983/discussion_topics/198365)